

The Ittar of Kannauj

India's four-hundred-year-old perfume city, and the distillation method that predates the modern lab

Learning Objectives

- Explain the history of Kannauj as India's centre of traditional perfumery
- Describe the deg-bhapka distillation method and how it differs from modern extraction
- Situate ittar within the broader heritage this Atelier has taught across every earlier course
- Apply this heritage with the same reverence taught throughout the Atelier

A city built entirely around scent

Long before "eau de parfum" existed as a category, the city of Kannauj in Uttar Pradesh had already built centuries of continuous, specialised perfumery craft around a single traditional method. This module asks you to learn that heritage by name, the way every earlier course has named the tradition behind a technique rather than treating it as generic "natural fragrance."



◆ Origin Story India · Kannauj

The City That Distilled Rain and Earth

Kannauj has been referred to as the "perfume capital of India" for centuries, its ittar (attar) trade documented as far back as the Mughal era, including references in the *Ain-i-Akbari*, the sixteenth-century administrative chronicle of Emperor Akbar's court. Its perfumers built an entire regional economy on a single traditional distillation method: *deg-bhapka*, in which flower petals, wood, or even earth are steam-distilled in a copper vessel called a *deg*, with the

aromatic vapour condensed and collected directly into a receiving vessel of pure sandalwood oil rather than alcohol.

This is how ittar produces its distinctive character — sandalwood oil, not alcohol, acts as the base, giving every Kannauj ittar a rich, oil-based depth entirely unlike an alcohol-based Western perfume. One of the most remarkable ittars produced this way is *mitti attar* — the scent of rain-soaked earth itself, distilled from baked clay, requiring no flower at all to capture one of the most evocative fragrances in nature.

At the Amber Atelier

When you introduce a client to ittar, you are not offering a novelty "Indian oil perfume." You are introducing her to a distillation tradition centuries older than the perfume houses of Grasse, still practised today by families who have done nothing else for generations.

Some cities are built around an industry. Kannauj was built around a craft. **Teach it as the craft it has always been.**

Ittar in a modern consultation

Because ittar is oil-based rather than alcohol-based, it typically develops more slowly on skin, carries a softer sillage, and lasts longer in its final dry-down than an equivalent alcohol-based fragrance — genuinely useful properties for a bride wanting a personal, close-worn scent rather than a room-filling one, a distinction Module Six will teach you to apply deliberately.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Ittar Comparison

Compare an oil-based ittar and an alcohol-based eau de parfum on skin over several hours, noting differences in development, sillage, and longevity. Record your observations for your capstone portfolio.